surrounded by marshes. The location was far from the mountains but had two airstrips suitable for landing B-26 bombers and could be defended effectively by a relatively small task force. Kennedy approved the new plan with one caveat. To ensure deniability he wanted a night landing on the island, with the ships carrying the task force to be removed from the area by dawn.

Kennedy decided to approve the invasion during the Easter break, following discussions with his father and his decision to accept Khrushchev's offer of a summit meeting at Kennedy's earliest convenience. With the invasion planned for Sunday, April 16, Kennedy decided to spend that weekend away from the White House at his family retreat in Glen Ora, Virginia. Since the media knew his whereabouts, this was one more ploy to deny involvement in the planned invasion not only on the part of American forces but also on that of the president. Far from relaxing at his hideaway, Kennedy would be on and off the phone again and again, following with growing anxiety the launch of the operation, which was codenamed "Zapata."[14]

◊◊◊

THE SHIPS CARRYING BRIGADE 2506, A FORCE OF CLOSE TO 1,400 Cuban exiles, left the shores of Nicaragua and headed for Cuba on the night of April 14. At 6:00 a.m. on April 15, eight B-26 bombers painted in the colors of the Cuban air force and piloted by Cuban exiles took off from airstrips in Nicaragua and headed for Cuban airfields with the task of destroying Castro's air force while it was still on the ground. The raid was declared a success, with the attackers unaware that quite a few of Castro's planes had remained undamaged.[15]

Fidel Castro fought back in the court of public opinion. That day Raúl Roa, the Cuban foreign minister, who happened to be in New York, managed to convince the UN leadership to convene an emergency meeting of the Political and Security Committee to discuss the airstrikes, which he characterized as a prelude to an American-backed invasion of the island. The American representative in the UN, Adlai Stevenson, repeated